

their proper place in history. But devotion to the gods and a passion for archæological learning seem to have worked ill for kingcraft. He was not building walls of defense, as had Nebuchadrezzar; he was not making an army, as had Nabopolassar. The slow growth of a mighty new power beyond his eastern borders made no impression on his absorbed mind. He had no political insight and could not see that the new power would soon be strong enough to covet his dominions and to take them. When Cyrus had driven the Medes out of Harran, Nabonidus glories in the "young servant of Marduk,"¹ as he calls him, but does not see that this young servant of Marduk would soon be driven by his own destiny and growing ambition to become his enemy and successor. On the contrary, Nabonidus brings an army to rebuild the temple in Harran, and lays his whole empire under tribute to pay the cost while he glories in the deeds of those whose royal hands had laid its early foundations.

Nabonidus lived in Tema, a place whose insignificance had given it no other mention in the annals of his country. There we can imagine him absorbed in great plans for temple building and restoration and engrossed in the work of his historiographers, who brought him their calculations of the dates when other kings had lived.

The affairs of state, the command of the army, the administration of public affairs had all fallen into the hands of the king's son, Belshazzar (Babylonian, *Bel-shar-usur*, "Bel protect the king"), who ruled in his father's name and enjoyed his confidence and affection.

Nabonidus seems to have neglected Babylon in very

¹ arad-su sa-ab-ri. Nabonidus, Abû-Habba, cylinder i, 29. Compare *Keilinschriftliche Bibliothek*, iii, 2, p. 98.